

History of Ancient Bengal

Map of Ancient Bengal



Territorial Unit (Janapad)

- ▶ The territory or geographical unit now known as Bengal used to be divided into many small territories, each known as 'janapad' and had a ruler. Following are the ancient 'Janapad' as evidenced by historical records:
- ▶ 1) Vanga or(Banga): Vanga was part of today's 24 Pargana district of West Bengal and Khulna Division of Bangladesh.
- ▶ 2) Pundra: Pundra was situated in the district of Bogura and adjacent areas.
- ▶ 3) Radha: Radha included a large part of West Bengal and was also described as Rarha and Ladha.
- ▶ 4) Gauda: Gauda included the northwest of Hooghly River and its core area is said to be Murshidabad.
- ▶ 5) Samantata: Samantata comprised of Comilla, Noakhali and some parts of Tripura.
- ▶ 6) Harikela: Harikela was part of Chittagong and adjacent areas.

Greek and Latin sources (3rd century BC - 1st century AD) refer to an eastern Indian nation/state called 'Gangaridae' (Greek)/'Gangaridai' (Latin) which was very strong militarily. Scholars have located 'Gangaridai' in parts of southern and southeastern Bengal, adjacent to the mouths of the Ganges (Bhagirathi and Padma).

Ancient Inhabitant

- ▶ Stone tools provide the earliest evidence of human settlements. Prehistoric stone implements have been discovered in various parts of West Bengal in the districts of Midnapur, Bankura and Burdwan. But it is difficult to determine, even approximately, the time when people using them first settled in Bengal. It might have taken place ten thousand years (or even more) ago. The original settlers were the non-Aryan ethnic groups- Nisadas or Austric or Austro-Asiatics - who are now represented by the primitive peoples known as Kola, Bhil, Santal, Shabara, Pulinda etc. At a subsequent age, peoples of two other ethnic stocks settled in Bengal, whose languages were Dravidian and Tibeto-Burman.
- ▶ Aryan influence in ancient India came to be felt in the northwestern parts in the middle of the second millennium BC and it took a long time for the Aryans to reach the eastern limits of the subcontinent. Thus the people of Bengal felt the tide of Aryanisation quite late. From about 5th century BC it pushed into Bengal from the west and it took about one thousand years to Aryanise the whole of Bengal. By the time Aryan

Bengal during the Mauryan and Gupta empires

- ▶ Mauryan Empire (320-180 BC)
- ▶ The **Maurya Empire** (c. 322-185 BCE) was the first pan-Indian empire, covering most of the subcontinent. Founded by **Chandragupta Maurya** with the guidance of his advisor **Chanakya**, it featured an efficient bureaucracy and a strong military. Its most famous ruler, **Ashoka the Great**, expanded it, embraced Buddhism, and promoted non-violence.
- ▶ **Capital: Pataliputra** (modern-day Patna) served as the imperial capital, a major hub for learning and administration.
- ▶ **Peak of Power:** Under Ashoka, the empire spanned over 5 million square kilometers and stretched across much of South Asia. **Legacy:** Ashoka's Edicts—carved on rocks and pillars across the empire—are the oldest deciphered written records in India. **Decline:** Following Ashoka's death, the empire fragmented and finally collapsed in 185 BCE when the last ruler, Brihadratha, was assassinated

Gupta Empire

The **Gupta Empire** (c. 320-550 CE) was a classical ancient Indian civilization that spanned much of the Indian subcontinent. Traditionally revered as India's "Golden Age," the era is famous for unprecedented advancements in **science**, **mathematics** (such as the concept of zero), **astronomy**, **literature**, and **Hindu art**.

Core Facts

- **Time Period:** c. 320-550 CE
- **Capital:** Pataliputra (modern-day Patna, Bihar)
- **Founder:** Sri Gupta (though Chandragupta I is credited as the first major emperor who built the empire)

Early kingdoms

- ▶ 1) The empire of Shashanka: Shashanka was the first independent king of ancient Bengal (600 AD-625 AD). He established himself in Gouda and made Karnasubarna in Murshidabad his capital. He extended his authority in Orissa and Bihar. He was a strong ruler.
- ▶ 2) Period of disorder or Matsyanaya. Following the death of Shashanka, disorder and lawlessness continued for about one hundred years.

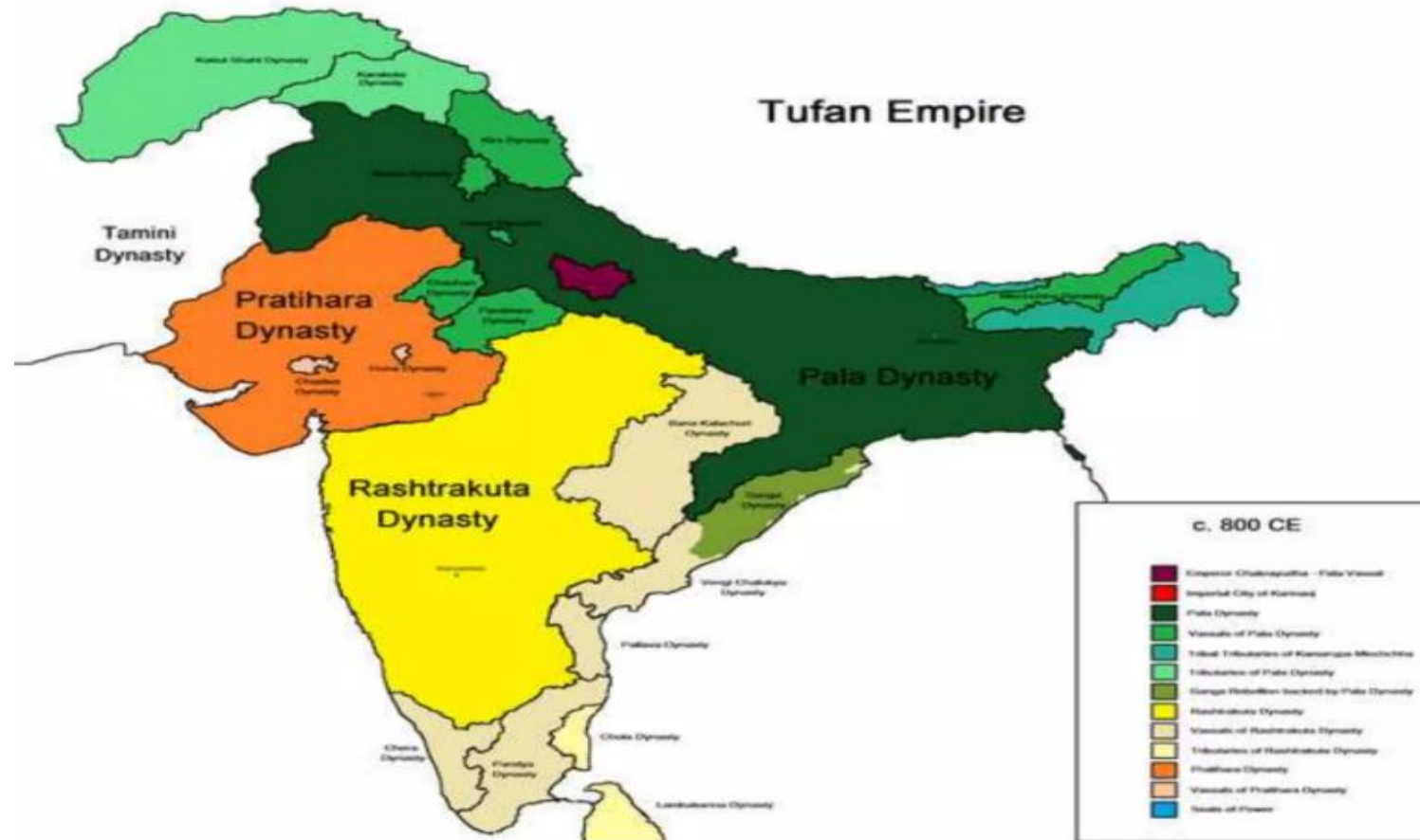
Bengal During Shasanka
c 500 to 700 AD



Pala dynasty (756-1160)

- ▶ 1) Gopal (750-770) was the first king and founder of Pala Dynasty. He brought an end to Matshanaya or lawlessness in Bengal.
- ▶ The dynasty ruled Bengal for about 400 years. Gopal is famous for establishing stability and peace in the kingdom.
- ▶ They are mainly Buddhist. Buddhism was major religion during this period.
- ▶ 4) The other kings of Pala dynasty are Dharmapala, Devpala, Mahapala, Rampala, etc
- ▶ **Buddhist Patronage:** The Palas were devout Buddhists and established legendary monastic universities such as Somapura Mahavihara (in modern-day Bangladesh) and Nalanda.
- ▶ **Religious Tolerance:** Despite being Buddhists, the Pala rulers were highly tolerant, patronizing Hindu temples and appointing Hindu scholars to high administrative positions.

Bengal during Pala



Sen Dynasty (1160-1206)

- ▶ 1) The dynastic rule was established by Bijoy sen ,He was feudal ruler under Pala dynasty.
- ▶ 2) This dynasty's rulers are migrants from Karnataka, they were devoted Brahmins and imposed upon the subject people a rigid caste system leading to dissatisfaction among common masses.
- ▶ 3) The other kings include Vallala Sena, Lakshmana.
- ▶ 4) This dynastic rule ended with defeat of Lakshmana Sena to Bakhtiyar Khalji in 1206.

